MOREH NEVUCHIM

Where Does God Dwell? Shechinah & the Language of Humans

Given Tuesday 10 November 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim I:25-26

Sefer: Moreh Nevuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed), Section 1

Chapters: I:25 — **שכן** (to dwell); I:26 — **דברה תורה כלשון בני אדם**

Shiur: Tuesday 10 November 2026, 8:00pm, on Zoom

Next week: a revision of all the verbs of motion, the one verb we haven't learned (**סבב**), then Chapters 27 and 28.

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Recap and a Clarification

Chapter 23, יצא (to go out): it can mean a physical departure, or a non-physical emergence, as in *כי מציון תצא תורה*. Of Hashem it means His will becoming manifest. **שב** means His *hashgahah* returning to its place: *אלך ואשובה אל מקומי*.

Chapter 24, הלך (to go): the movement of creatures; of things like water and fire; the spreading of something non-physical, like a sound; and a person's moral conduct. Of Hashem it means the withdrawal of *hashgahah*, or the spreading of an effect from Him.

A correction from last week

Last week the Rabbi gave the impression that once *hashgahah* is removed, whatever happens to a person is random. Doron picked him up on it after the shiur, and he looked into it during the week.

It is true that without hashgahah a person is left to chance. But that does not stop Hashem from punishing someone deliberately, in proportion to what they did.

So in *ויחר אף ה' בם וילך* (Miriam and Aharon), **וילך** carries both meanings at once:

1. Hashem withdrew His *hashgahah*.
2. His anger spread, and the punishment showed itself in Miriam's *tzaraat*.

Why Miriam and not Aharon? Perhaps she started it. Either way, the anger spread.

Robert asked whether we have discussed God "getting angry", which sounds like an anthropomorphism. It's coming up in a later chapter.

Chapter 25 — שכן, To Dwell

Chapters 22 to 24 were all about *hashgahah*: coming, going out, going. So it fits that Rambam now turns to **שכן**, the root of the word **שכינה**. It is the last of the verbs of motion.

Meaning 1: living somewhere, while moving within it

The plain meaning is to dwell: *והוא שכן באלני ממרא*, and *ויהי* **ידוע שמשמעות פועל זה היא להתגורר.** *בשכן ישראל בארץ ההיא.*

Rambam adds a detail: a creature that stays in a place for a long time is said to dwell there **גם אם הוא נע בו בלי ספק**, even though it is certainly moving around inside it.

שוכן and יושב

The Rabbi's own suggestion (*"could be true, could not be true"*): **ישב** means to settle in one spot and stop moving. **שכן** means to live in a general area while moving around in it.

That may be why Hazal read **וישב יעקב** negatively. The verse could have said *וישכן*. *וישב* suggests he wanted to stop, almost to retire, and so: *ביקש יעקב לישב בשלוה, קפץ עליו רוגזו של יוסף*.

The same distinction explains two more words:

	The word	Why
The Mishkan	From שכן	It travelled with Bnei Yisrael for 400-plus years. The Shechinah was constant, but the building moved. The two Temples, fixed in one place, are called **מקדש**
A neighbour	**שכן** (*שכן טוב*, Avot)	You live near him, but he isn't essential to you. You don't choose a neighbour the way you choose a **חבר**

Meaning 2: something resting on something, even non-physical

הדבר הושאל גם למה שאיננו בעל חיים, and even to something attached to a thing that is not a place.

היום ההוא יהי חשך... תשכן עליו עננה (Iyov 3)

Iyov wishes the day of his birth had stayed dark, with a cloud resting on it, so that the sun never rose and he was never born. *A cloud is not a creature, and a day is not a body at all, only a stretch of time.* Yet the verse says *תשכן*.

שכן and Hashem

Whenever שכן is used of Hashem, it is the second meaning. It means the constant presence of either:

	What it is	The verses
Shechinah	His created light, *אורו הנברא*	*וישכן כבוד ה' על הר סיני; ושכנתי בתוך בני ישראל*
Hashgahah	His attention, His involvement	*ורצון שכני סנה*

כל מקום כענייננו: which one it is depends on the context.

What is the "created light"?

Rambam has quoted Onkelos on created light before (Chapter 5, the burning bush; Chapter 21), and you get the sense he isn't fond of the literal reading. The created light works on two levels:

1. **Simply:** an actual, physical light. Measure the room and there would be more light in it.
2. **Deeper, and what Rambam prefers:** a light created **in a prophetic vision**. Nothing physical; a manifestation of Hashem in the mind of the prophet.

"If you struggle, understand it as a physical light. But you should be aiming to understand it as created light in a vision."

So at Har Sinai, every one of Bnei Yisrael had a prophetic experience in their minds, a created light. As the Gemara says, a simple person at the revelation had a greater prophetic experience than Yehezkel HaNavi.

ורצון שכני סנה

ומגד ארץ ומלאה ורצון שכני סנה תבואתה לראש יוסף. (Vezot HaBerachah)

Moshe blesses Yosef: may the same will and *hashgahah* that Moshe experienced at the burning bush come to Yosef's head, all his life. Here *שכן* means *hashgahah*.

The Mishkan is not holy by itself

Whenever Hashem promises to dwell among us, the condition is the mitzvot. To Shlomo: *הבית הזה אשר אתה בנה, אם תלך בחקתי... ושכנתי בתוך בני ישראל.*

"The Mishkan isn't, in itself, a place of Shechinah. It's a place where Hashem rests His hashgahah."

The Rabbi has said the same about the Kotel: it is holy because there we focus more on Hashem, so our prayers are better received. *"If you go to the Kotel and pray exactly as you pray anywhere else, it's nothing."*

Rav Makbili points to the Rambam in Mishneh Torah:

מצות עשה ליראה מן המקדש... ולא מן המקדש אתה ירא אלא ממי שצוה על יראתו.

We are not in awe of the bricks, the tapestries or the gold. We are in awe of Hashem's presence within it.

לשם יחוד... לאקמא שכינתא מעפרא

Many say these words every day; *"95% couldn't tell you what they mean."* Raising the Shechinah from the dust means raising awareness: tuning in again to the created light and

the *hashgahah*, instead of neglecting them.

"I'm not saying we should say Leshem Yihud. I'm saying that when we say these words, this is what they mean."

Maor's question

Maor asked: in the Second Temple there were corrupt kohanim, yet people brought their offerings to them. How did that work?

"That's the thing!" That is why things didn't work as they should, why the high priests were dying every year, and why the prophets lamented: **מי בקש זאת מידכם רמס חצרי.** The Shechinah in the Second Temple was not the same as in the First.

Maor also posted in the chat: **רני ושמחי בת ציון כי הנני בא ושכנתי בתוכך נאם ה'.**

Chapter 26 — דברה תורה כלשון בני אדם

For about fifteen chapters, from Chapter 10, Rambam has explained the verbs of motion one by one. Before turning to feelings and body parts (foot, face, back, from Chapter 28), he pauses to ask the general question: **why does the Torah use these anthropomorphisms at all?**

Paragraph 1: the language of people

דברה תורה כלשון בני אדם. The Torah speaks in words people can understand.

שכל מה שיכולים כלל בני אדם להבין או לתפוס במחשבה ראשונה, הוא שיוחס להשם יתעלה.

Whatever people grasp **at first thought** is what is attributed to Hashem. Most people, *בעיון ראשון*, only recognise what has a body; what has no body doesn't exist for them. So Hashem is described in physical terms **to teach that He exists**.

Notice that Rambam says **first** twice: *מחשבה ראשונה, עיון ראשון*. At the end of the chapter he says that reading the Torah this way is reading it like **נערים**, like children.

Why Jewish education can fall short

"There may be great Jewish education in primary and high school. The problem is that beyond that, people don't study further, and they're left with a childish conception of God."

It may be right to teach a child that Hashem is here and Hashem is listening. The problem is staying there.

Abaye and Rava (Berachot 48a): Rabbah asked the two young boys, *למי מברכין?* "To Rahmana." *ורחמנא היכא יתיב?* Rava pointed to the ceiling; Abaye went outside and pointed to the sky. *תרוייכו רבנן הויתו*: "you'll both be rabbis."

Rabbah knew God isn't up there. We link height with importance, so the highest place, the heavens, is where we picture Hashem. For a child that is fine. *"But you need to grow up from that."*

Who first used this phrase this way?

In the Gemara, *דברה תורה כלשון בני אדם* appears **only in halachic contexts**, never for derash. For example, *הענק תעניק* and *השב תשיבם*: one Tanna learns something from the doubled verb, the

other says the Torah simply speaks as people do.

Rambam applies it to non-halachic verses. **He was not the first.** Professor Michael Schwartz, a modern commentator on the Moreh, notes that **Rabbeinu Bahya ibn Paquda**, a century earlier, wrote in *Sha'ar HaYihud* of the Hovot HaLevavot: *ועל כן אמרו רבותינו... דברה תורה כלשון בני אדם*. The Kuzari does it too.

Paragraph 2: only "perfections" are attributed to Hashem

וכן כל מה שהוא שלמות אצלנו יוחס לו. Anything people see as a perfection is said of Hashem.

כל מה שההמון משיג שהוא חסרון והעדר, אינו מתואר בו. Anything people see as a lack is never said of Him.

Said of Hashem	Never said of Hashem
Moving, coming, going, standing, sitting	Eating, drinking, sleeping, illness, oppression
People think of these as perfections	Even at first glance, people see these as deficiencies

But these "perfections" are perfections only **for us**. **ביחס אליו יתעלה, כל מה שאנחנו חושבים שהיא שלמות אינה אלא חסרון.**

Paragraph 3: moving is no better than eating

Movement is a real perfection of living creatures. We need it to reach what suits us and to run from what doesn't.

כי כשם שהוא זקוק לאכילה ושתיה... כך הוא זקוק לתנועה.

"I go downstairs because I'm thirsty. I go out to a meeting because I need a livelihood." We move because we need something, just as we eat because we need to.

People are embarrassed to eat in public but not to walk. Yet **ואין הבדל במציאותו יתעלה בין שיאכל וישתה לבין שיתנועע**. For Hashem there is no difference; both are needs, and Hashem needs nothing. The Torah only uses movement because, at first thought, people see it as good.

Paragraph 4: no movement, and no rest

Aristotle showed that **anything that moves has size and is divisible**. Rambam will prove that Hashem has no size or body, so He has no movement.

ואין לתארו גם כן נח. Nor can He be described as resting, because rest belongs only to things that move.

It is like saying Hashem is *alive*. As Rambam writes in Yesodei HaTorah: *"God isn't alive, He is life."*

Once we remove physicality, all of these go too:

ירד, עלה, הלך, נצב, עמד, סבב, ישב, שכן, יצא, בא, עבר.

Rambam says it would have been unnecessary to go on at length, **אלמלא מה שהורגלו דעות ההמון**, and that he writes to remove *the light dust of the ideas people started with in*

childhood.

Revision Round

The Rabbi asked the class which of Rambam's eleven verbs we haven't learned. **סבב**, to go around. That comes next week.

Then a quick revision, which ran out of time:

Verb	Of Hashem it means	Chapter
ירד	Resting the Shechinah; giving prophecy; punishment (*ארדה נא ואראה*)	10
עלה	Prophecy ending, the Shechinah departing (Doron)	10
נצב	Permanence (and more meanings, to revise)	—

"Go over the notes every month or so from the beginning. You need to have the whole thing in front of you."

Summary

Chapter 25, שכן: it means to live in a place while moving within it (so the portable Mishkan, and a neighbour), or something resting on something else, even non-physical (a cloud on a day). Of Hashem it always means the second: the constant presence of His **Shechinah**, a created light, ideally understood as in a prophetic vision, or His **hashgahah**. Holy places are holy because there we turn to Hashem: *ולא מן המקדש אתה ירא*.

Chapter 26: the Torah speaks in human language, for people's first thought, so that they know there is a God. It uses only what people see as perfections, like movement, never eating or sleeping. But for Hashem, movement is as much a deficiency as eating, and He cannot even be said to rest. All the verbs of motion must be understood figuratively.

Coming Up

Next week: revision of all the verbs of motion (please go over the notes), the verb **סבב**, then Chapters 27 and 28.

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